

heroine or the symbolism of fertility. The affinity to heritage monuments could be related to notions of romantic love as manifested in sites such as the Taj Mahal.

Fantatising about erotic intimacy or more abstract lust can be linked to sites of solitude or/and to the thrill of doing something in the realm of an 'illegitimate', 'unsuitable' place, where the erotic tension is generated precisely through the knowledge of doing something morally improper. Internalised voyeurism, the idea of being watched while engaging in something 'unsuitable', is part of the kick. Making love at home may be all right while its display in public allegedly insults public sentiments, morale and traditions. That's what the survey reveals us a whopping 60 per cent fantasising about having sex in their bedrooms.

When I came to India for the first time in 1986, I was puzzled by the notion that solitude seemed to be difficult to find and furthermore, was not particularly aspired for. Intimacy was something to be kept out of the public, hardly practicable. These rules of the social gaze seem to apply even within the walls of a 'traditional' joint family house and the fact that many families share the same bedroom. With economic liberalisation, the notion of solitude and privacy became a brand of a 'good lifestyle', of 'world-class'. Modern flats for the affluent sported bedrooms for each member of the family or for the married couple. Honeymoon trips of the new middle-class shifted from crowded places like Shimla or Kathmandu to spas in Goa and Kerala, remote islands in Thailand, beaches in Australia or holiday resorts in Egypt. With this translation of new lifestyles, in particular, in India's cities, affecting an educated, English-speaking middle-class, and new sites of conspicuous consumption such as cafes, shopping malls and day spas, the fantasising of having sex opened up existing new places; the office, college, beaches, hotels, cars or kitchen tables. So far, so good.

What seems to be worryingly growing, simultaneously however, is the restriction of these places for the 'everyday wo/man'. The fantasising either remains an imaginary act or faces resistance of kinds. No wonder only 29 per cent could actually make out in other places of fantasy outside their bedrooms. Instead of a liberalisation of public space and moral values vis-à-vis the new concepts of romantic love, and particularly non-arranged love, we can see an aggressive control over and closure of public space and tolerance. Take two examples. The first one is related to the attacks on lovers in public places, especially in parks. These attacks may range from an annoyed and appalled staring to verbal insults to physical harassment and, more recently, photographic or filmic documentation and circulation with the intention of public denunciation. The general argument goes that the display of intimacy in public is equally offensive to the 'common man', keeping families from visiting those parks and hurting Indian culture to which the concept of romantic love is said to be essentially foreign and thus wrong. The places of fantasised love turn into nodal points of vul-

Of all the places you fantasise about, where have you had sex?

In the bedroom	71
In a bedroom decorated for a wedding night	33
In a hotel room	27
In the bathroom	21
Under a tree, in a park	7
Balcony of the house	5
In a car	5
In the kitchen	4

For 4,222 respondents of the total 5,371 who have had sex. Figures add up to more than 100 because of multiple choices. All figures in per cent.

Mumbaikars seem to be moving up the fantasy chart. Fifty-six per cent want to have sex on a beach, 47 per cent under a waterfall and 26 per cent under a tree in a park.